CYBER SAFETY GUY

ONLINE CHALLENGES & TRENDS:

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

Challenges and trends spread fast online. They can be fun, silly or creative. Some can be risky or even dangerous.

Here's what parents need to know.

89% of teens say they have seen online challenges — Pew Research (2023)

1 IN 5 teens say pressure to take part is common — Ofcom (2023)

46% of parents find it hard to keep up with new trends — Internet Matters (2023)

NEW trends appear quickly and can go global in hours or days

1 WHAT THEY ARE

Short-term themes or activities that go viral online.

2 HOW THEY SPREAD

Shared on social media, group chats and video apps.

3 WHAT KIDS WANT

Fun, belonging and likes. Feeling included.

4 WHY THEY WORK

Curiosity, FOMO (fear of missing out) and peer pressure.

5 THE RISKS

Some trends are harmless. Others can cause harm.

6 THE CONVERSATION

Talk early. Listen openly. Focus on choices, not fear.

TYPES OF ONLINE CHALLENGES & TRENDS

Physical Challenges
Dares or stunts that can cause injury.

Appearance Challenges
Focus on looks or body image.

Risky Behaviours
Encourage dangerous or illegal activities.

Prank & Trick Trends
Pranks that can be hurtful or scary.

Misinformation Trends
False info or hoaxes that spread quickly.

Positive & Creative
Kindness, creativity and awareness trends.

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **Most trends are short-lived.**
But the impact can be long-lasting.

2. **Not all trends are bad.**
Some build skills, creativity and awareness.

3. **Peer pressure is powerful.**
Kids may join in to fit in, not because they want to.

BY THE NUMBERS

64% of teens say they've seen a challenge that worried them — Pew Research (2023)

28% of teens say they've felt pressured to join in — Ofcom (2023)

3 IN 4 trends start on short-video platforms before spreading — BBC (2023)

< 24 HRS some trends go from unknown to viral in a day — TrendWatch (2023)

SAFETY FEATURES / SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS

Privacy Settings
Control who can see posts and videos.

Comment Controls
Limit or block comments.

Content Filters
Filter sensitive or inappropriate content.

Report & Block
Report harmful content and block users.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set accounts to private.
- Limit who can comment or message.
- Turn on content filters where available.
- Check who can see your child's content.
- Talk about locations and personal info.

STEP-BY-STEP: KEEP YOUR CHILD SAFE

1. **Stay informed.**
Keep up with the apps and trends your child uses.
2. **Talk regularly.**
Ask about what they're seeing and doing online.
3. **Check the facts.**
Research trends together. Not everything is safe.
4. **Set boundaries.**
Agree on what's okay and what's not.
5. **Encourage critical thinking.**
Is it safe? Is it kind? Is it legal? Is it worth it?
6. **Know where to get help.**
Save numbers and report tools. You're not alone.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

Physical Injury
Stunts or dares can cause serious harm.

Emotional Harm
Shame, bullying or stress from joining in or missing out.

Online Pressure
Repeated pressure can affect mental wellbeing.

Exposure to Harmful Content
Some trends lead to violent, sexual or disturbing content.

Privacy Risks
Sharing personal info or locations can be dangerous.

Long-Term Impact
What goes online can affect future opportunities.

THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION

- What trends or challenges have you seen recently?
- Does anything make you feel pressured to join in?
- What would you do if a challenge felt unsafe?
- Who could you talk to if you were unsure?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE
Open conversations build safer choices.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Stay calm. Listen and support.
- Take screenshots or save messages.
- Note dates, times and usernames.
- Do not delete evidence.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Report to the platform or app.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Contact Childline if you need support.
- Get help from school if needed.

You did the right thing. Help is available.

NEED TO TALK? **CHILDLINE** | **0800 1111** childline.org.uk | **YOU ARE NOT ALONE** We're here for you.